

Capra aegagrus

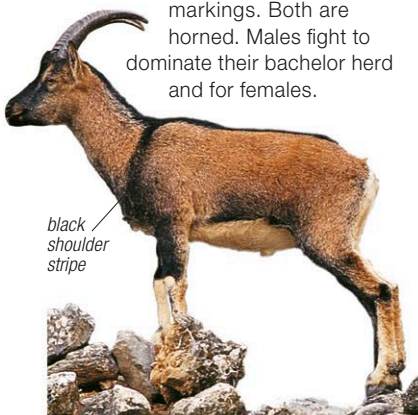
Wild goat



Length 4–5¼ ft (1.2–1.6 m)
Tail 6–8 in (15–20 cm)
Weight 55–210 lb (25–95 kg)
Location W. Asia
Social unit Group
Status Vulnerable



The wild or Bezoar goat, probably the ancestor of domestic goats, grazes and browses in varied habitats, from arid scrub to alpine pasture, at elevations up to 13,800 ft (4,200 m). Females are red-gray to yellow-brown; adult males (a young male is pictured) are bearded and silver-gray with dark markings. Both are horned. Males fight to dominate their bachelor herd and for females.



Capra falconeri

Markhor



Length 4½–6 ft (1.4–1.8 m)
Tail 3¼–5½ in (8–14 cm)
Weight 70–245 lb (32–110 kg)
Location C. and S. Asia
Social unit Variable
Status Endangered



The markhor occupies various habitats at 2,300–13,200 ft (700–4,000 m), eating tussock grass in summer, and shrubby leaves and twigs on lower slopes in winter, when its short, red-gray coat becomes longer and grayer. The spectacular spiral horns reach 5¼ ft (1.6 m) in the shaggy-throated males, yet only 10 in (25 cm) in the females. The horns are one reason why the markhor is threatened by hunting.

Pseudois nayaur

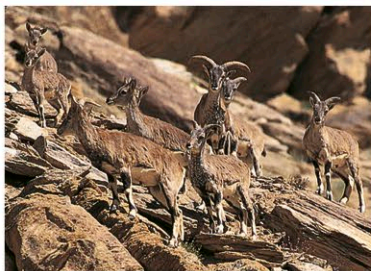
Greater blue sheep



Length 4–5½ ft (1.2–1.7 m)
Tail 4–8 in (10–20 cm)
Weight 55–175 lb (25–80 kg)
Location S. to E. Asia
Social unit Group
Status Least concern



Also called the bharal, the greater blue sheep is camouflaged to survive in rocky, icy alpine zones between tree- and snow-lines. Males are brown-gray, tinged with slate-blue, white below, with a white eyebrow strip, and black flanks and leg stripes. The smooth, 32-in (80-cm) horns splay outward. Females are smaller with shorter horns, and lack most of the black markings. Breeding habits resemble other sheep, with rams competing for harems.



Ammotragus lervia

Barbary sheep



Length 4¼–5½ ft (1.3–1.7 m)
Tail 6–10 in (15–25 cm)
Weight 88–320 lb (40–145 kg)
Location N. Africa
Social unit Individual/Group
Status Vulnerable



The rufous-tawny coat of the Barbary sheep, or aoudad, has a short, upright mane on the neck and shoulders, and a much longer one on the throat, chest, and upper forelegs. Both manes and the crescent-shaped horns, up to 33 in (84 cm) long, are more developed in males. These sheep eat a wide variety of plant matter. Males charge each other, heads lowered, for dominance and access to female groups for breeding.

Ovis ammon

Altai Argali



Length 5½–6 ft (1.7–1.8 m)
Tail 3¼–4¾ in (9.5–12 cm)
Weight 175–390 lb (80–175 kg)
Location C. and S. Asia
Social unit Individual/Group
Status Near threatened



Male Altai argali not only charge and clash heads when rutting but also run in parallel and butt the opponent's flank and chest. Also called arkhar, this is the largest wild sheep, with elaborate, ridged horns—up to 5 ft (1.5 m) in males—that corkscrew sideways, twisting 360 degrees or more with age. The coat of this very gregarious bovid is variably pale brown with white legs and rump patch. Like many wild sheep, it is threatened by human hunting, and habitat loss to livestock. Twin young are relatively common.

Ovis canadensis

Bighorn sheep



Length 3¼–6 ft (1–1.8 m)
Tail 4–6 in (10.2–15.2 cm)
Weight 120–320 lb (55–145 kg)
Location S.W. Canada, W. and C. USA, N. Mexico
Social unit Individual/Group
Status Least concern



The bighorn sheep's glossy brown summer coat of brittle guard hairs over crimped gray underfur fades in winter. Before the rut, males display, walk away from each other, turn, advance with a threat jump, and then lunge to head butt with enormous force. This may continue for hours until one gives up. The 1–3 young are born after a gestation period of 170–180 days.

OUT OF REACH



Like many wild sheep, when threatened, bighorn sheep use their gripping hooves and climbing ability to retreat to nearly vertical rocky bluffs and cliffs, where few predators can follow. The young bighorns learn about seasonal pathways and suitable habitats from adults in their group.

Ovis gmelini

Anatolian sheep



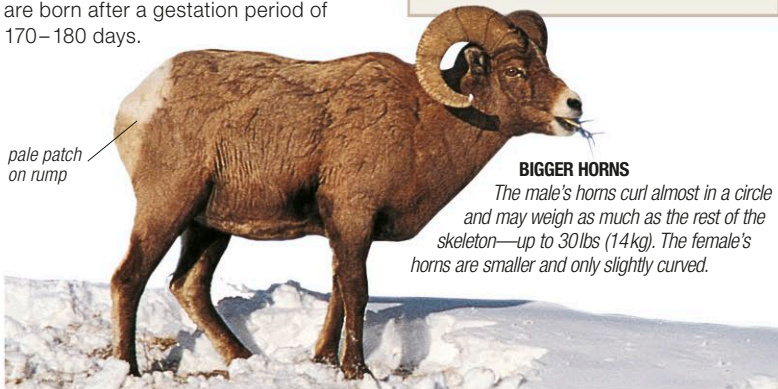
Length 4–4¼ ft (1.2–1.4 m)
Tail 2¼–4½ in (11–13 cm)
Weight 77–150 lb (35–67 kg)
Location W. Asia
Social unit Individual/Group
Status Vulnerable



The smallest wild sheep, and probable ancestor of all domestic breeds, the Anatolian sheep frequents uplands and shrubby, grassy plains. The coat is red-brown with a dark central back stripe flanked by a paler "saddle" patch, a short, broad, dark tail, and paler underparts. The curved horns are



pale patch on rump



BIGGER HORNS

The male's horns curl almost in a circle and may weigh as much as the rest of the skeleton—up to 30 lbs (14 kg). The female's horns are smaller and only slightly curved.